2025

2025

2025

2025 was a foundation year for the Travellers' Archive. The focus was on establishing the systems, relationships, and research practices that will sustain a transnational archive in the long term. This meant sitting inside Swiss archives, identifying topic of Nigerian interest, testing annotation software refining metadata principles, and beginning the slow work of bringing together family memory and institutional history.

The year closes with a strong organisational base, a growing constellation of archival partners, and a clear sense of the method that will guide the project:
a visual-intelligence approach that keeps archives alive without flattening non-Western voices.

2026

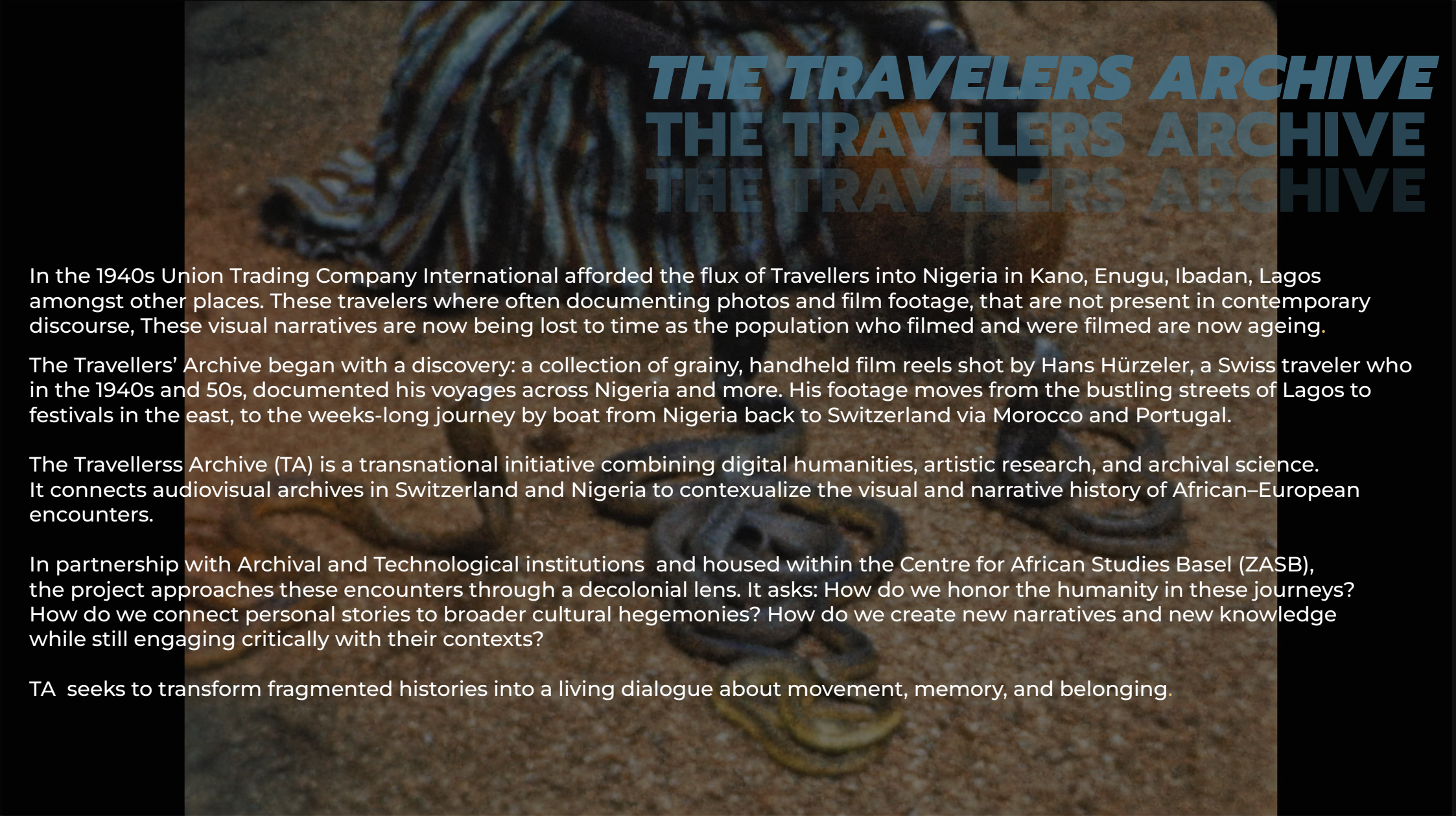
2026

2027

2026 is conceived as a year of consolidation. The initial focus will remain on the Swiss side of the project, where archival access, rights, and technical standards must be stabilised before any large-scale public release or international expansion. This includes formalising provenance and consent pathways, refining metadata and annotation practices with the Digital Humanities Lab, and preparing a digitisation pipeline that aligns with Memoriav's standards. During this period, the project will continue to work closely with Archival Partners to clarify what can responsibly enter the public archive and under what conditions.

At the same time, 2026 will be the year in which the Travellers' Archive becomes legible to others. The first workshop at the Centre for African Studies Basel will articulate the project's method and emerging research questions, while the film development process moves from collection and selection toward narrative structure. By the end of the year, the archive is expected to exist as a defined corpus rather than a growing field of possibilities.

2027 is planned as a year of activation. With the Swiss infrastructure in place, the project can turn outward. This includes initiating structured partnerships with Nigerian institutions, expanding the archive through Nigerian held family materials, and beginning the public-facing phases of the film and exhibition.
Across both years, the project maintains a single guiding principle: the archive is not an endpoint but a living system. Technical decisions, curatorial choices, and narrative structures are treated as provisional and revisable, allowing the archive to grow without flattening complexity or silencing marginal voices.



THE TRAVELERS ARCHIVE

THE TRAVELERS ARCHIVE
THE TRAVELERS ARCHIVE

In the 1940s Union Trading Company International afforded the flux of Travellers into Nigeria in Kano, Enugu, Ibadan, Lagos amongst other places. These travelers where often documenting photos and film footage, that are not present in contemporary discourse, These visual narratives are now being lost to time as the population who filmed and were filmed are now ageing.

The Travellers' Archive began with a discovery: a collection of grainy, handheld film reels shot by Hans Hürzeler, a Swiss traveler who in the 1940s and 50s, documented his voyages across Nigeria and more. His footage moves from the bustling streets of Lagos to festivals in the east, to the weeks-long journey by boat from Nigeria back to Switzerland via Morocco and Portugal.

The Travellerss Archive (TA) is a transnational initiative combining digital humanities, artistic research, and archival science. It connects audiovisual archives in Switzerland and Nigeria to contexualize the visual and narrative history of African–European encounters.

In partnership with Archival and Technological institutions and housed within the Centre for African Studies Basel (ZASB), the project approaches these encounters through a decolonial lens. It asks: How do we honor the humanity in these journeys? How do we connect personal stories to broader cultural hegemonies? How do we create new narratives and new knowledge while still engaging critically with their contexts?

TA seeks to transform fragmented histories into a living dialogue about movement, memory, and belonging.

GALLERY

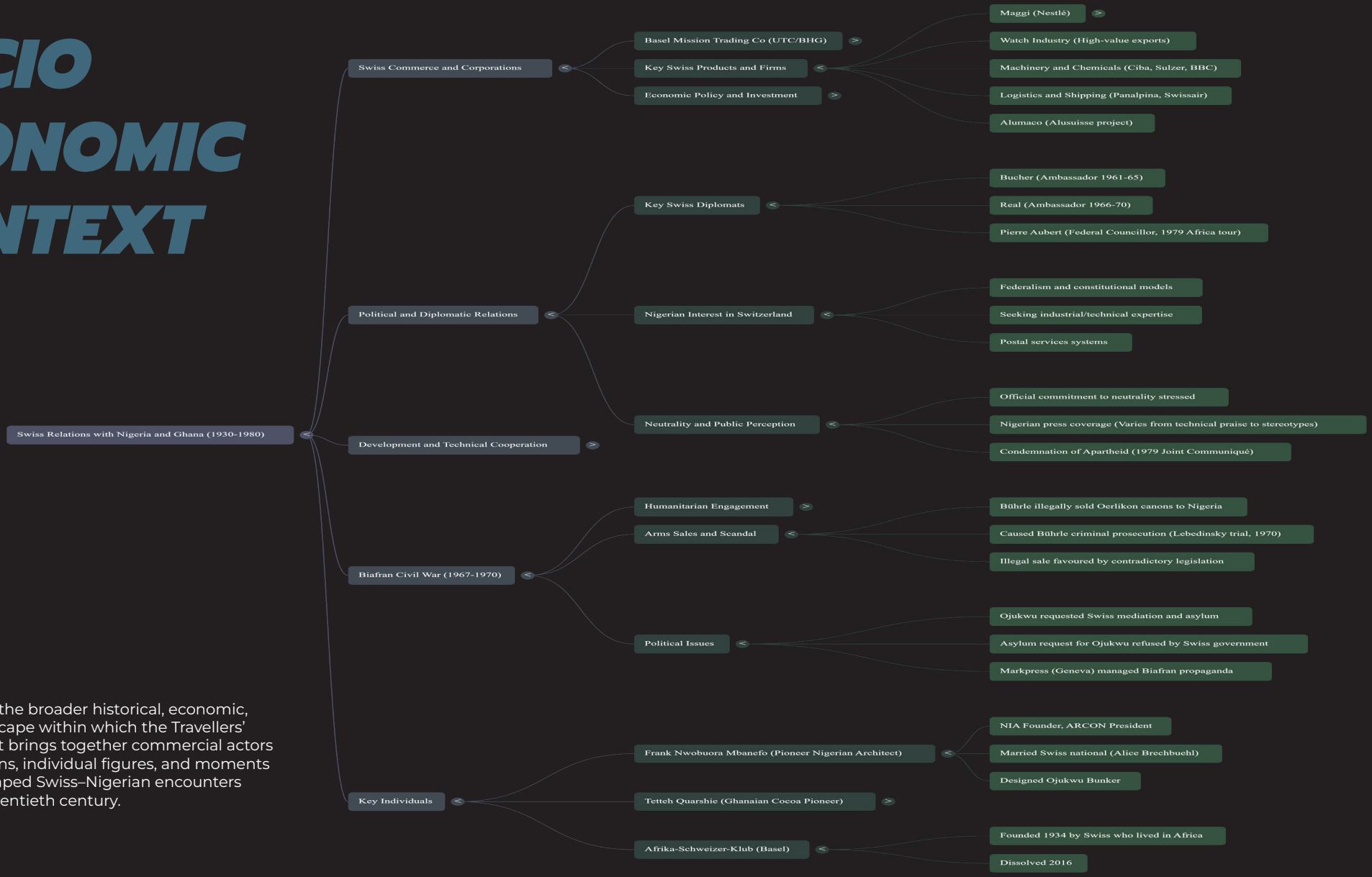









SOCIO ECONOMIC CONTEXT



This map outlines the broader historical, economic, and political landscape within which the Travellers' Archive operates. It brings together commercial actors diplomatic relations, individual figures, and moments of rupture that shaped Swiss–Nigerian encounters during the mid-twentieth century.

INSTITUTIONAL PROGRESS

Centre for African Studies Basel

As the project's home institution, the Centre for African Studies provided the academic ecosystem needed to stabilise the archive's conceptual and methodological pathways. The fellowship gave space to define the research arcs, refine archival questions, and begin shaping what will become a public workshop at ZASB in early 2026. A new line of inquiry also emerged from this environment: ethnographic computation, a method for analysing film materials using both qualitative insight and computational logic.

Lichtspiel / Kinemathek Bern

Lichtspiel has become one of the project's central institutional anchors. In 2025, time was spent studying their Nigeria holdings, reviewing catalogues, and identifying films that deepen the socio-economic, cultural, and personal arcs of the archive. Rights have been cleared for the use of screenshots, and interviews with the Lichtspiel team are scheduled for the new year. Many of their reels some already digitised internally, some still untouched have now been mapped as core candidates for the Travellers' Archive corpus.

Mission 21

Mission 21 holds a vast, largely uncatalogued Nigeria collection of films, photographs, and documents. Much of this material lacks provenance, metadata, or rights clarity. The visit to the archive surfaced both a major opportunity and a structural challenge: Mission 21's Nigeria footage is rich but inaccessible, and digitisation cannot proceed until a rights and provenance strategy is built. Mission 21 has invited a formal proposal, and this will shape an important strand of work for 2026.

Basler Afrika Bibliographien

Through BAB, the project digitised a few key objects of insight related to our reseach small but significant fragments that trace Swiss-Nigerian personal networks. These now function as a seed list for tracing family connections may still hold private film reels or photo albums from their time in Nigeria.

Storie Kulturagentur

Storie.ch supported the development of project budgets and the formation of the Traveller's Archive Association. Their guidance helped stabilise the organisational structure needed for long-term film, exhibition, and publication outputs.

Digital Humanities Lab (DH Lab, University of Basel)

Beginning January 2026, the DH Lab will support the refinement of the project's metadata schema, standardisation workflows, and digital readiness. This collaboration is key for moving the archive toward compliance, structured annotation, and a future public-facing digital platform.

RESEARCH

1. Socio-Economic Networks

Fieldwork in the Wirtschaftsarchiv, Mission 21, and BAB strengthened the economic history foundation of the project. Records from companies such as UTC, Nestlé, AluSwiss, and Burla (linked to Biafra-era controversies) were identified as central actors in the mid-twentieth-century Swiss presence in Nigeria. The project began an entity index with five companies to prevent the research from becoming unwieldy.

The Nigeria materials both cinematic and textual make this contradiction visible.
Swiss participation in Nigerian trade, shipping, agriculture, and retail (e.g., UTC supermarkets) formed an economic fabric that survives in memory even where the institutions themselves have disappeared.

2. Travel, Memory, and Personal Archives

Family histories remained a priority, and 2025 marked the first steps in formalising an oral-history pipeline.
A new descendant interview will be conducted with the Hürzeler and Müller families, audio-recorded and added to the corpus.
A Nigerian-Swiss link, Frank Mbannefo, was identified as part of the wider historical network.
A community workshop in Burg im Leimental brought descendants together around shared archival fragments.
The project also began experimental annotation using Experimental Vidoe Archive (EVA), an open annotation tool developed by Visual Intelligence and Talking Objects Lab.
Two film clips were annotated as a pilot, helping test how digital tools can support a participatory, ethically grounded archive.
Emerging affective motifs include trade, cocoa and agricultural labour, weaponry and militarisation, financial flows, and the fragile but persistent idea of “Nigerian unity” visible in footage of daily life and events like the OAU conference.

RESEARCH

3. Cultural Production and Visual Practices

A motif taxonomy is underway, drawing from Lichtspiel's reels and Mission 21's uncatalogued materials.
Themes such as ritual movement, market life, trade, cocoa production, weapons, and the performance of unity appear repeatedly.

Collaborations with contemporary artists are planned for the Nigerian phase, but 2025 focused on observing, cataloguing

4. Power, Provenance, and Institutional Histories

This arc sharpened the ethical and structural challenges ahead.

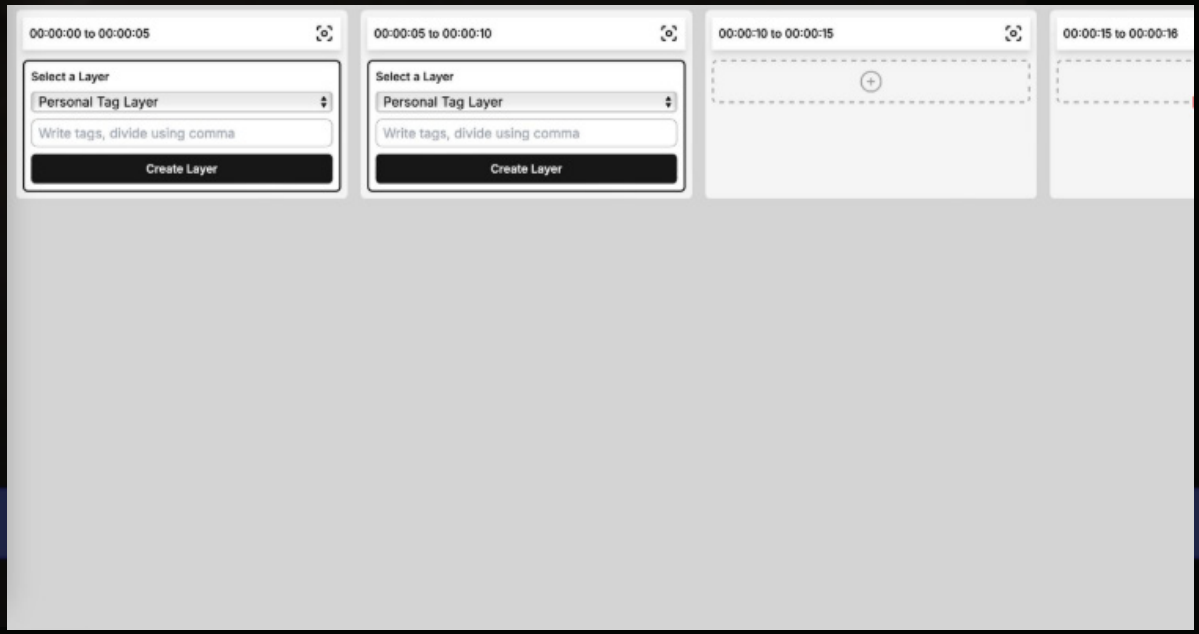
Mission 21's archive illustrates the difficulty of working with large collections lacking provenance, rights documentation, or cataloguing. This led to the decision to frame provenance and sensitivity review as major project objectives for 2026.

Progress was made with Lichtspiel, who clarified rights for image use. The naming convention designed for the Travellers' Archive is now in active use, ensuring consistency and traceability across digital assets.

TECHNICAL RESEARCH

A key strand of technical research in 2025 focused on testing how archival film material can be meaningfully annotated without reducing it to flat metadata. In collaboration with **Visual Intelligence** and **Talking Objects Archive**, the Travellers' Archive was given early access to EVA, an open annotation environment designed for close, frame-level engagement with audiovisual material. EVA allows annotations to remain layered, contextual, and reversible, supporting multiple readings of the same image rather than enforcing a single authoritative description.

This collaboration enabled an initial experimental phase in which two archival film clips were annotated to test how motifs, entities, affective readings, and provenance notes could coexist within a shared digital workspace. The aim was not full implementation, but methodological testing: understanding how visual intelligence tools might support participatory annotation, descendant input, and future hypermedia storytelling across the project's four research arcs. These experiments directly inform the project's broader technical direction, which treats annotation as an interpretive act rather than a purely extractive one, aligning with the project's pre-project research framework and ethical approach to cultural heritage data.



OUTPUTS- NODULAR ARCHIVE





BY BOAT, BY MEMORY

BY BOAT, BY MEMORY
BY BOAT, BY MEMORY

By Boat, By Memory is the primary public expression of the Travellers' Archive. It exists as both a film and an artistic exhibition, conceived together rather than as separate outputs. Each format approaches the archive from a different angle, but both are grounded in the same material: archival film, personal memory, contemporary encounters, and the long afterlife of Swiss–Nigerian relations.